Hearing Aid

By Pete Barry

INTRODUCTION

ACTRESS: *Getting older means things stop working without warning.*
ACTOR: *Hearing fades. Backs ache. Knees negotiate every movement.*
ACTRESS: *Simple conversations become obstacle courses.*
ACTOR: *A single sentence can trigger confusion, accusation, or emotional collapse.*
ACTRESS: *Often all three.*
ACTOR: *What happens when a quiet evening at home quickly turns into a full-scale argument?*
ACTRESS: *This couple navigates the hazards of "aging together" and decades of shared history with . . .*
ACTOR: *No hearing. No filters and no patience.*
BOTH: *Hearing Aid by Pete Barry*

Two loud, competing noises: a melodramatic TV show and Bach's Goldberg Variations. She listens to the radio, her ear up against the speaker. He watches TV, squinting.

OLD WOMAN: **(Pgs 374-382)** *(turns the music down a little. She removes her hearing aid and checks it)* Battery's dead.

OLD MAN: Is he? I knew he'd come to no good.

OLD WOMAN: What?

OLD MAN: What'd they do, shoot him?

OLD WOMAN: *(indicating the radio)* It's not Schubert, it's Bach.

OLD MAN: Who's back?

OLD WOMAN: Whose back? Your back?

OLD MAN: *(indicating the TV)* Jerry Orbach hasn't been on for years. This is *CSI.*

OLD WOMAN: See whose eye?

OLD MAN: No, I haven't seen Jose. I thought you were talking about Barry.

OLD WOMAN: I was what?

OLD MAN: You said, "Barry's dead."

OLD WOMAN: It's nothing to be embarrassed about, your back.

OLD MAN: I'm not harassing you about it. I'm just asking.

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OLD WOMAN: You get old, things don't work so well anymore. *(turns off the radio)*

OLD MAN: Ah, come on, now, I missed half of what this girl was talking about. I can't figure this show out.

OLD WOMAN: I'd better go make dinner. *(starts off toward the kitchen)*

OLD MAN: If you're going in the kitchen, bring me a cold Heineken.

OLD WOMAN: *(shoots him a quizzical look)* What?

OLD MAN: Wouldja just bring me a Heineken?

OLD WOMAN: What for?

OLD MAN: Not four! Just one!

OLD WOMAN: I'm going as fast as I can.

OLD MAN: What d'ya think I am, some kind of alcoholic? *(She goes. He yells at the TV)* I can't watch this garbage anymore. I'm gonna do the crossword. *(switches off the TV and gets the newspaper and a pencil. He counts.)* 13? Hey! 13 letters! What's a 13-letter word for "nearly deaf"?

OLD WOMAN: *(off)* What's the question?

OLD MAN: NEARLY DEAF!

OLD WOMAN: *(off)* "BANK OF AMERICA"!

OLD MAN: *(pause)* Well, it's 13 letters.

OLD WOMAN: *(returns, empty-handed)* You shouldn't sit there watching TV all day if it's gonna make you this cranky.

OLD MAN: What happened to my beer?

OLD WOMAN: You shaved it off six months ago.

OLD MAN: You don't have to save beers. It's not like there's a shortage or something.

OLD WOMAN: It was never very long. You weren't like a Nazarene.

OLD MAN: What?

OLD WOMAN: You know, like Jesus grew it.

OLD MAN: *(sarcastic, indignant)* That's a real nice thing to say!

OLD WOMAN: It's historical.

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OLD MAN: I'm not getting hysterical!

OLD WOMAN: What's the matter?

OLD MAN: You're crazy, that's what!

OLD WOMAN: Then turn up the thermostat!

OLD MAN: I'm like a big joke. *(OLD WOMAN seems surprised at this, but considers it. She sniffs the air)* A target for stray insults. A waste of space doing the crossword. Nobody even listens to a word I say. Like I'm talking to the wind. *(continues to sniff the room. shrugs)*

OLD WOMAN: *(continues to sniff the room. shrugs)* I don't smell anything. But I can't hear anything, either, I guess. Are you sure? *(He stares at her, blankly. She sniffs again)*

OLD MAN: What are you doing?

OLD WOMAN: You smelled cigar smoke?

OLD MAN: What about cigar smoke?

OLD WOMAN: You said you smell cigar smoke?

OLD MAN: WHAT ABOUT CIGAR SMOKE?

OLD WOMAN: YOU SMELL CIGAR SMOKE?

OLD MAN: I DON'T SMELL CIGAR SMOKE.

OLD WOMAN: YOU SAID YOU SMELL CIGAR SMOKE.

OLD MAN: I SAID I ***DON'T*** SMELL CIGAR SMOKE!

OLD WOMAN: Why are you yelling?

OLD MAN: If I don't yell you don't listen to me!

OLD WOMAN: I can't listen if you don't talk to me!

OLD MAN: I'm talking to you right now!

OLD WOMAN: You're not talking, you're yelling!

OLD MAN: What do you want me to do?

OLD WOMAN: Stop yelling and say something!

OLD MAN: Say what?

OLD WOMAN: Say anything!

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OLD MAN: HOW MUCH WOOD COULD A WOODCHUCK CHUCK IF A WOODCHUCK COULD CHUCK WOOD!

OLD WOMAN: You don't have to be vulgar.

OLD MAN: Are you ever gonna get me a Heineken?

OLD WOMAN: Were you serious?

OLD MAN: Why would I want cereal with a Heineken? Do you mean poured over the cereal?

OLD WOMAN: Whatever you want.

OLD MAN: That's the worst thing I've ever heard of. Never mind. I'll take my comfort in the crossword puzzle. *(She goes. He tries the crossword again)* Four down. "One-eyed Rat Packer." "Sammy." What? Seven letters. Uh. "Davis"? No. "Junior"? What? Four down. "One-eyed Rat Packer." That's "Sammy"! What's wrong with this puzzle? Four down, "One-eyed Rat Packer"! Seven letters! Am I insane? FOUR DOWN, "ONE-EYED RAT PACKER"! Oh, four ***across***. *(fills it in)*

OLD WOMAN: *(rolls in a gold-painted shop window mannequin)* Were you saying you were going to design and build a four-man juice squeezer?

OLD MAN: What the hell is that?

OLD WOMAN: [A mannequin.] You asked for it.

OLD MAN: Are we opening a boutique?

OLD WOMAN: What about Little Bo Peep? Is that a clue in the crossword?

OLD MAN: *(yelling)* So, I'm doing the crossword! Is that a crime?

OLD WOMAN: You're yelling again!

OLD MAN: Does that give you the right to make a mockery of me?

OLD WOMAN: "The right maid to muck around with"? What does that mean?

OLD MAN: I'm not here for your entertainment, for your merriment!

OLD WOMAN: You made a mistake ... marrying me?

OLD MAN: No, I don't need a steak marinade!

OLD WOMAN: 'Cause you know, I coulda done better!

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OLD MAN: Oh, I'm a dumbbell, am I?

OLD WOMAN: You don't appreciate what you've got!

OLD MAN: Oh, I'm a breezy-eight used car, am I?

OLD WOMAN: You'd be lost without me! You'd destroy the closets, burn the laundry, shatter the glasses, let mold grow everywhere! You'd call strange people at all hours of the night! You'd spin out of control! You wouldn't get a nice dinner, I'll tell you that! You can't even make a fried egg!

OLD MAN: Shows what you know! It's not Friday! It's Thursday!

OLD WOMAN: If you're thirsty, then go get yourself a Heineken! *(collapses in tears)*

OLD MAN: Hey. Hey now. What's wrong?

OLD WOMAN: This marriage is not working anymore. After 42 years, it breaks my heart to say it. We don't communicate. I'm leaving.

OLD MAN: If you're freezing, then turn up the thermostat. *(She turns to leave)* Wait! Wait a minute. *(She stops)* There's something wrong here and I just don't understand what.

OLD WOMAN: Well, I can't stand it either.

OLD MAN: We talk and the sentences don't fit together.

OLD WOMAN: It has become like a prison sentence.

OLD MAN: Everything I say gets all twisted around. Either I'm not saying what I mean or you're not hearing what I say. And I can't figure it out and it makes me hate everything.

OLD WOMAN: I can't hear what you're saying, I'm too upset.

OLD MAN: What'd you say? I didn't hear you.

OLD WOMAN: *(points to the radio)* I used to love music so much. I can't hear it anymore. I hear sounds, but they're not distinct. There's no rhythm or pitch. It's all noise. It was such a joyous part of my life and now it's gone. It's infuriating. And it just makes it worse when you yell at me for something I can't help. So why should I stay, just to get yelled at? *(He looks from her to the radio, really trying to understand, but clearly lost)* You can't hear a word I'm saying. Forget it. *(turns to leave)*

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OLD MAN: Wait! *(She turns back. He turns on the radio)*

OLD WOMAN: I just told you I can't hear it.

OLD MAN: What?

OLD WOMAN: I CAN'T HEAR IT!

OLD MAN: NEITHER CAN I! *(begins to dance. He is awkward, totally off the rhythm, but he commits to it wholeheartedly. She manages an unenthusiastic smile. He beckons to her)*

OLD WOMAN: I can't dance to it. I can't hear it.

OLD MAN: Come on. C'mere. *(She goes, reluctantly. They sway together. He puts his lips up to her ear. Softly)* Can you hear this?

OLD WOMAN: Yes.

OLD MAN: How about *(whispers in her ear)*

OLD WOMAN: *(smiles)* Yes. *(He whispers again. She giggles. She whispers in his ear. He laughs, a loud hearty laugh. They engage in a merry whispering conversation while dancing to a beat)*

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AWARD HISTORY

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